Democracy's Data: Analytics and Insights into American Elections

[84–355] | Fall 2026

Prof. Jonathan Cervas

Updated: August 20, 2026

> Professor Jonathan Cervas
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> Location: Porter Hall A21A
> Time: Tuesday & Thursday 11:00a-12:20p Eastern
> Office Hours: Wed 10:30a-12:30p & 1:30p-3:30p, and by appointment (arrange via email)
> **CMU Academic Calendar**

The most up-to-date version of this **syllabus can be found here**: https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-355/readme.html

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> **Course Relevance:** DC: *Perspectives on Justice and Injustice* **Learning Resources:** All resources will be provided via Canvas
> **Prerequisites:** 36-200 Reasoning with Data

25 meetings, Tuesdays and Thursdays. One of them, **Tue, Nov 24**, meets on Zoom rather than in the room. The tinted days are closures — fall break, Democracy Day, Thanksgiving, and the Constitution Day Symposium.

How American elections actually work, taught through the data they produce. Tuesdays we read; Thursdays we put real election data on the screen and work out what it shows — through the 2026 midterms, live.

01 Assessment

The course grade will be a weighted average of the following components:

Category	Percent of Final Grade
Participation & Attendance	15%
Discussion Board	20%
Weekly Data Contributions	10%
Three Tests (10% each)	30%
Data Journalism Project	25%

What each one is:

- **Participation & Attendance** — Being here, prepared, and in the conversation — on both days.
- **Discussion Board** — By Friday night each week, one post about any of the data we talked about: the lab, a classmate's data slide, a figure in the reading. Something that surprised you, something we missed, something you do not understand, or an answer to somebody else's question. **A few sentences to a paragraph** — enough to show you engaged with what we did. One post is full credit.
- **Weekly Data Contributions** — Find data bearing on the question Tuesday ended with, name the source, and post it as a slide before Thursday. Each week two slides are drawn at random and worked through in class, and nobody presents the data they found themselves. **If your name is drawn and you are absent or have no slide, it costs 25% of your attendance grade for the semester** — expect your own data to come up once or twice all term. At the end of term you hand in a **newsletter**: every piece of data you found, each with a short write-up. **Build it as you go** — it is a paragraph a week, and an evening's work if you leave it all to December.
- **Three Tests** — In class, on paper, and **on the textbook only**. Test 1 on **Tue, Oct 20** (Sides et al., Chapters 1–5), Test 2 on **Tue, Nov 10** (Chapters 6–9), Test 3 on **Thu, Dec 3** (Chapters 10–13). We read the book straight through in its own order, so each test is a block of consecutive chapters: each covers the chapters read since the last one, **none is cumulative**, and every chapter appears on exactly one test. There is no final exam.

- **Data Journalism Project** — A data-driven news story about a trend or issue in electoral processes. Runs in three parts — draft, peer review, final — and **most of the marks are on the first two**. It is the only substantial piece of writing this term.

02 Due Dates

Assignment	Due
Data slide	before **each Thursday**
Discussion board post	**Friday, 11:59 p.m.**, each week
Data Session 4 board post (no Thursday session)	**Tue, Sep 22** — no session to follow that week, so you get the weekend
Week 14 board post (Thanksgiving)	**Mon, Nov 30** — Tuesday is the lab, and there is no Thursday
Data journalism: pitch	**Thu, Oct 8**, in class
Test 1 — Ch. 1–5	**Tue, Oct 20**, in class
Test 2 — Ch. 6–9	**Tue, Nov 10**, in class
Data journalism: **draft**	**Thu, Nov 19** — the last session before the break
Data journalism: **peer reviews** (two)	**Tue, Dec 1**
Test 3 — Ch. 10–13	**Thu, Dec 3**, in class
Data newsletter	**Fri, Dec 4** — the last day of classes
Data journalism: **final**	**Fri, Dec 11** — after the last session

There is no final exam.

03 The Essentials

- **Required text**: Sides, Shaw, Grossmann & Lipsitz, *Campaigns and Elections* (W. W. Norton). Everything else is posted on Canvas — there is nothing else to buy.
- **No coding, and nothing to install.** Every lab arrives as a prepared data brief with the results already in front of you; what you do is work out what they show.
- **Tests are on the textbook only** — in class, on paper.
- **Due Wed, Aug 26, 11:59 p.m.**: the Cervas Election Study — link in **Canvas, under Assignments**; screenshot the confirmation screen for credit. It is the first thing due, and Thursday's session uses it.

04 The Full Syllabus

The session-by-session schedule, every reading and lab, assignment details, and all policies:

https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-355/readme.html